foot then left foot. Eric was one of the best players in Europe and he was doing the same stuff I'd done with Dad in Chase Lane Park when I was seven years old.

Once you're playing soccer as a professional, you have to spend most of your time preparing for two games a week. It doesn't leave much opportunity for the basics: controlling and striking the ball. My dad had always tried to make sure I understood that control was the most important skill of all. It didn't matter what else you learned, a good first touch was the key. Which was why Eric, an established international, always made sure he found time to work on that. If you're comfortable receiving the ball, it gives you the room in your game to see what you need to do next. The manager has told this story about Eric on the eve of the 1994 FA Cup Final. He saw him outside in the hotel grounds, just practicing on his own, and realized then that Eric was a player who set his own standards higher than anybody else could set them for him. He was an example to all of us, the boss included.

It wasn't that he set himself up as a leader. Before he came to England and while he was at Leeds, I don't think that part of Eric's character particularly stood out. Once he got to United, everything changed. It was as if he'd found the place he belonged and the stage he thought he deserved. In a United shirt, what he did was amazing right from the start. It was Eric's arrival three months into the season that was the key to United winning the League in 1992/93, putting an end to all those years of waiting for the club. Then the following season, he helped United to our first Double.

I didn't play in the first team during those two seasons, but when we did eventually play together, I could tell Eric must have been the spark that made it all happen. He led. The rest of us followed. It's a rare quality: a born captain, who hardly needed to say anything, to us or anybody else. You didn't hear Eric leading the team. Just seeing him on the field, standing there with his collar turned up, ready to take on the world, was enough.

When people talk about Eric, they'll always refer to the sendings off, and worse, during his career. The way I see it, though, all great players have an edge to their character and to their game. That edge is what makes them more than the ordinary. And if you go through a whole career with that quality, you're bound to have trouble with the authorities sooner or later. It may sound strange but despite the bookings, sendings off, bans or whatever, it would never have occurred to me to criticize Eric. We played soccer together and that was what my relationship with him was all about. I'd think about him, about what he brought to the dressing room and the team: his ability, his